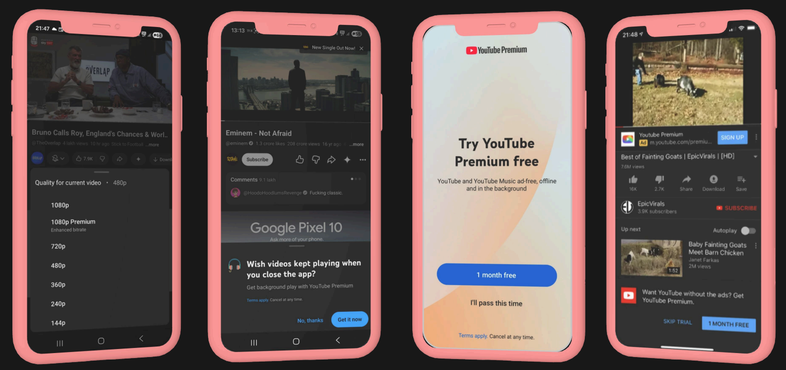
Premium

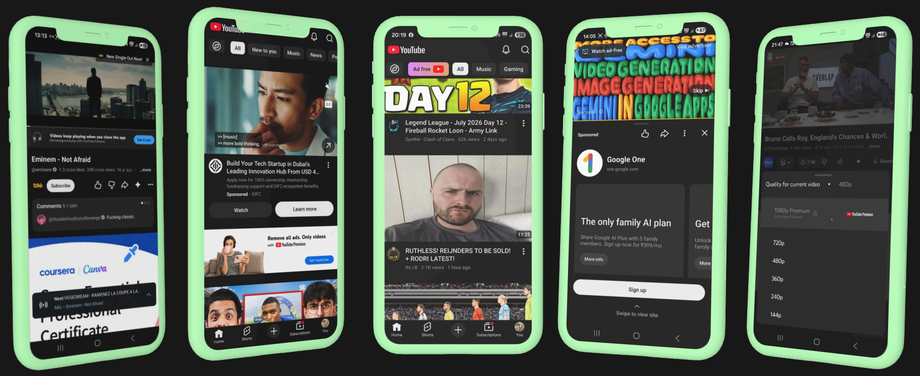
Improving the YouTube experience through intuitive Premium promotions





Problem : YouTube Premium promotion popups/nudges are obtrusive and irritating to the free user

Solution : Improved YouTube Premium promotions with better nudge timing, placement, and contextual offering

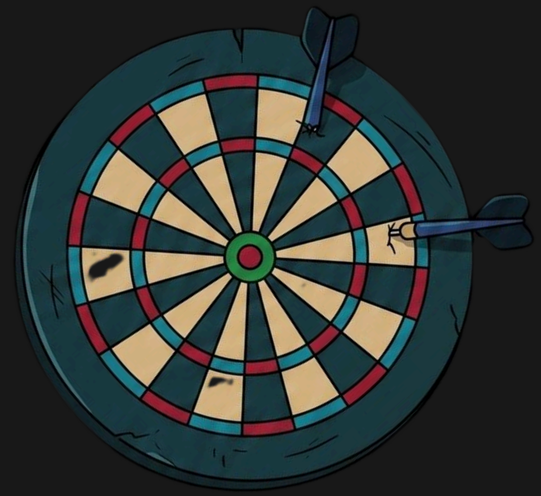


Problem Brief :

Make YouTube Premium nudges feel helpful instead of intrusive without compromising subscription growth

Context : Frequent YouTube Premium prompts interrupt the viewing experience and can frustrate users.

Goal : Create subtle, contextual nudges that encourage Premium subscriptions without disrupting the experience.

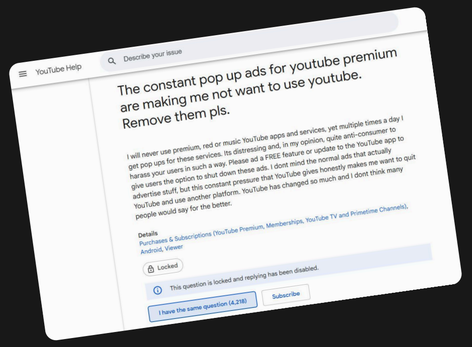


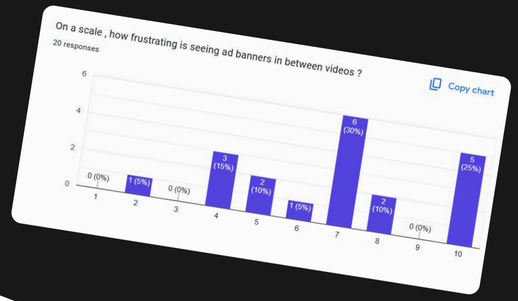
Validating the problem (Qualitative + Quantitative)

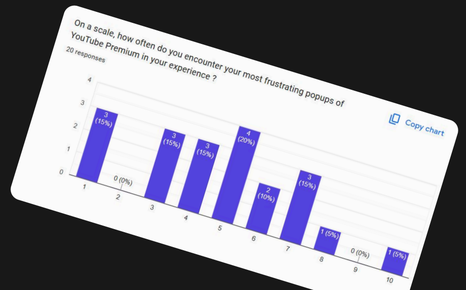
YouTube Premium promises an ad-free experience, yet its own promotions frustrate viewers

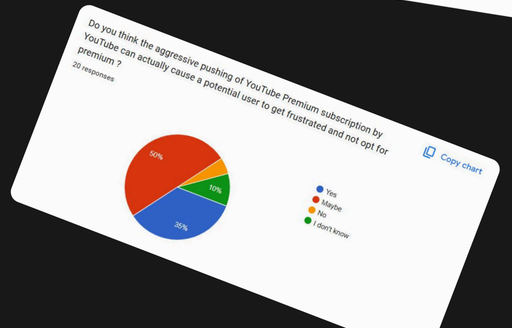
- Considerable complaints and frustrations have been recorded by free plan users regarding the repetitive popups and promotions of the YouTube Premium subscription on forums.
  [Source - Google support, Android authority, Reddit and Quora (2023-26)]

- A qualitative study involving 20 regular users of YouTube also shared the same pattern of irritation











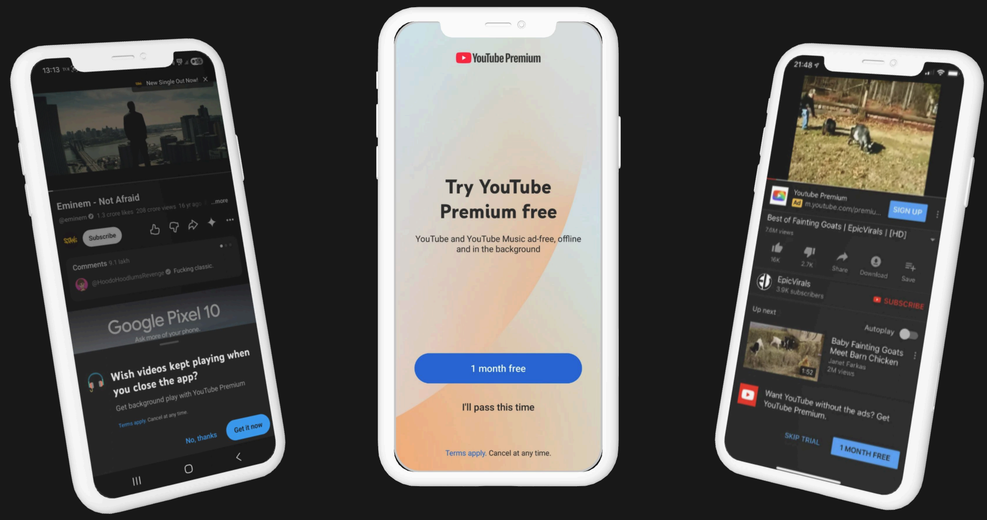
Psychological Reactance (Brehm, 1966)

When users feel their freedom to choose is restricted, they naturally resist. Even with a Skip button, the interruption can trigger a boomerang effect, making users more resistant to the message.

Forced-Exposure Intrusiveness Model (Edwards, Li & Lee, 2002)

Forcing users to view a message increases perceived intrusiveness, leading to irritation and ultimately causing users to dismiss or avoid both the ad and the product.





A user wants to simply open YouTube and watch some videos

BUT...

they are interrupted by aggressive Premium promotions

Excited/Ready to watch videos

Annoyed at Premium popup at app launch

Enjoying videos until...

Frustrated at Premium's popup after Ad in video

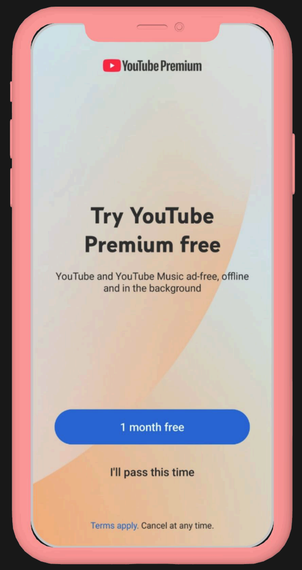
Ad plays in some other video

Dreading another popup

Frequent interruptions fuel resentment

Proposed Solutions

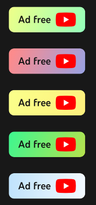
1.

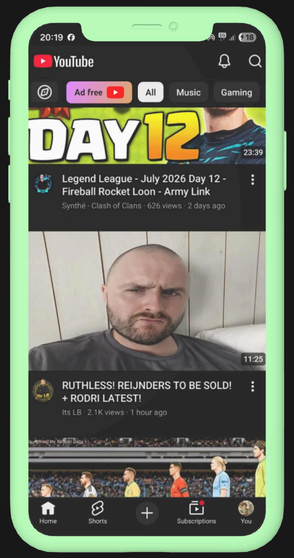


Present pattern

The interstitial pop-up at app launch

- Reduces user control through forced interaction
- Delays the user's primary task i.e, watching videos
- Hampers predictability of system
- Increases time in interaction and feedback
- Increases cognitive load by prompting users to interact to skip





Improvement

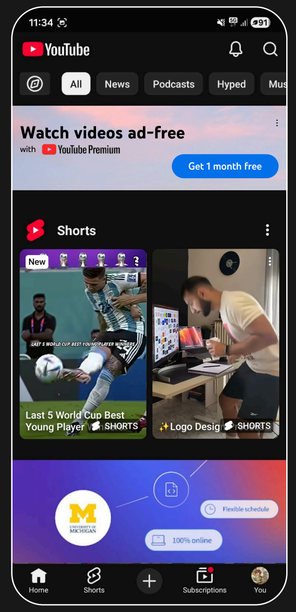
An ad chip living in the top navbar

- Contrasting color for discoverability
- Ubiquitous yet unobtrusive
- Users get the freedom to interact with ad offer
- Primary task is achieved without waylaying
- Predictable behavior of system

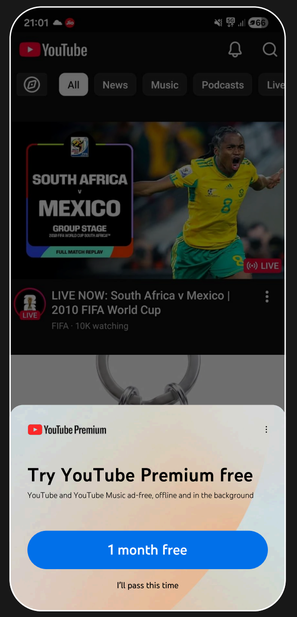
Ideas explored but deprioritized...



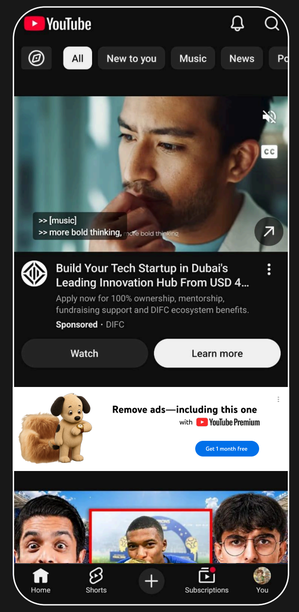
Low visibility & discoverability



Ads block most valuable screen real estate

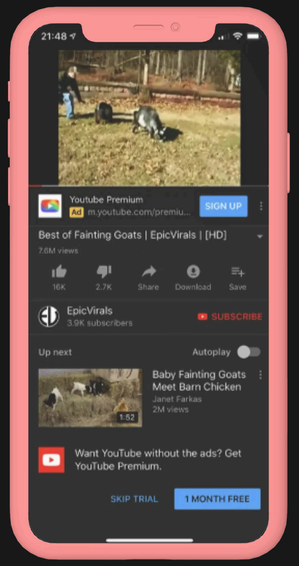


- Obtrusive pattern
- Extra cognitive load
- Delaying user's goal



- Ad blocks valuable space
- Potential Banner blindness

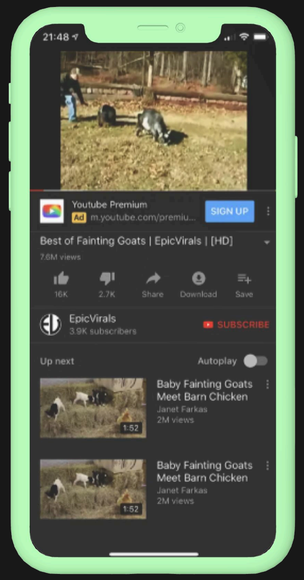
2.



Present pattern

The promotional bottom sheet

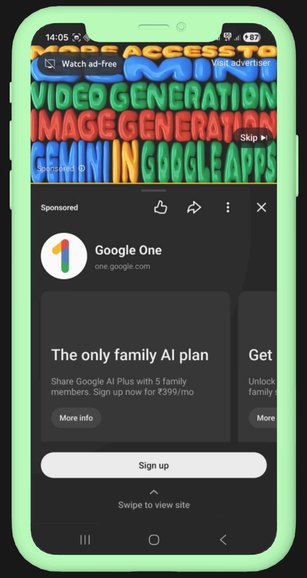
- Obstructing user during their peak journey
- Reduces user control through forced interaction
- Delays the user's primary task i.e, watching video
- Increases cognitive load by prompting users to interact to skip



Improvement #1

Removing the bottom sheet

- The post-ad Premium banner is contextual enough
- Banner isn't obtrusive yet discoverable
- This improves all the frictions the user feels

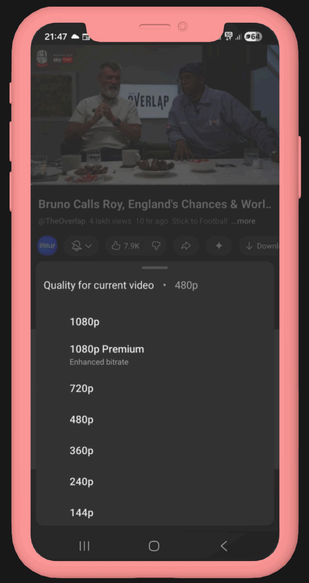


Improvement #2

"Watch ad-free" overlay after 3 seconds into the ad

- Improved context of the promotional offer
- High discoverability
- User freedom is maintained
- Unobtrusive

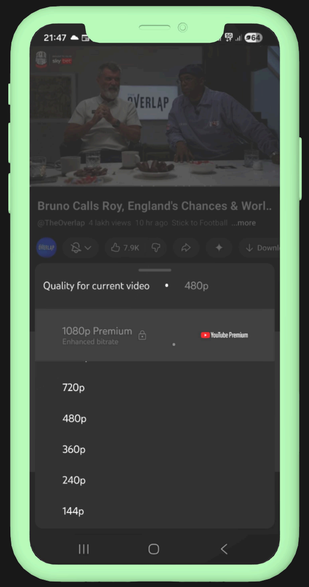
3.



Present pattern

1080p Quality change setting in videos

- Violates predictability as a quality setting unexpectedly becomes an upsell trigger



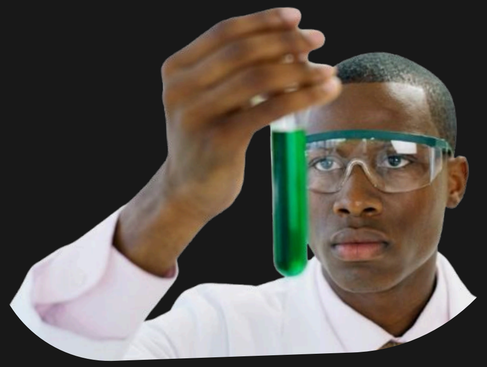
Improvement

Better help and documentation to inform

- Deprioritized using subtler grey to communicate locked state
- Lock logo to amplify communication
- YouTube Premium logo indicates required subscription

All the proposed solutions were backed by usability heuristics researched by NN/ Group

But the real test was if regular YouTube users liked them....





I invited 46 regular YouTube users to anonymously review the ideas and provide unfiltered feedback

46
casual users

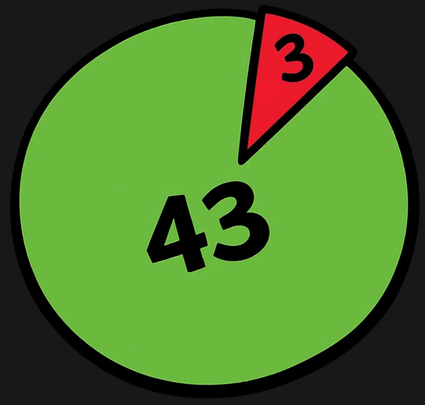
22-46
Age group

Unfiltered
reviews on concepts

Usability test results

43 out of **46** loved the improved propositions.

That's **93%** of the test group



They vehemently shared their stance on the current prompts and ad pop-ups of YouTube Premium as **"irritating"** and **"intrusive"**

However the common consensus was that the proposed improvements would **make their experience easier and less perturbing**.





Thank you